

[Return to Search](#)

Veiled sentiments

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Zariba's case illustrates the priority of honorable behavior over ascribed positions based either on age or wealth. He violated the code of honor by failing to control his passions; he chased women and was shameless in that he made obscene comments. By being irresponsible toward his family, and thus not fulfilling his role as provider, he violated the pact assuring that the dominant provide for the weak. Although older than most of the men with whom he associated, he no longer received their respect.

156
[Social Personality](#)

558
[Downward Mobility](#)

577
[Ethics](#)

The man who needs women is called either a fool (*habal*) or a donkey (*hmar*), both epithets alluding to an absence of ' *agl*. The bestial insult is applied to the man who seems not in control of his sexual appetites. Men who took many wives, whether wealthy (as was one man reputed to have married thirty-two women during his lifetime) or poor (as was another who took whatever money came his way to pay the bride-price for another wife, even though he could not feed or clothe the ones he had) were often called donkeys. The term was also applied to adulterers and men who frequented prostitutes. These men were described as *bita' sabaya*, literally, belonging to women. Depending on the consequences of their acts they were either denounced or merely ridiculed. Disapproval was severe when the men neglected their familial responsibilities, failing to provide adequately for their dependents. When it [94](#) did not jeopardize the welfare of dependents, the same behavior merely exposed the men to ridicule. Behind their backs, women described such men's interests in obscene gestures and bawdy jokes; they considered them fools for being driven by sexual desire.

577
[Ethics](#)

578
[Ingroup Antagonisms](#)

595
[Polygamy](#)

626
[Social Control](#)

834
[General Sex Restrictions](#)

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